

How to actually help in the first days

A card for birth partners — Mark Harris

Where we are: most women in this country start breastfeeding. By the baby's first birthday, only about one in six still is. Ask the researchers why they stop and you get the same three answers women gave in the 1990s: *"I didn't have enough milk", "sore nipples", "he wouldn't latch."* Every one of those is fixable with the right support. And the biggest thing driving women to stop is **contradictory advice**. That's where you come in.

Your job: learn the machine

If you understand how milk is actually made, you become the one person in the room who can't be argued with — not by being louder, but by knowing. That's the whole job.

Six things to know

1. **Milk is made to order.** Supply follows demand. Feeding often *is* how the milk gets made.
2. **Empty breast, fast factory.** Milk left sitting in the breast sends a "make less" signal. Skip feeds, and the factory downsizes.
3. **Tonight's feed makes tomorrow's milk.** The hormone surge peaks *after* the feed — so feeding now builds the next one.
4. **The stomach is tiny.** On day one it holds a marble's worth. Colostrum is exactly enough. The baby isn't starving.
5. **Letdown is shy.** It needs her calm, warm, safe and unobserved. Stress and interruption stall it. Your quiet helps more than you'd think.
6. **Skin to skin is medicine.** It calms the baby and builds the milk. Take your shift — chest to chest.

The one question that cuts through everything

"What does this advice do to the physiology?"

Shields, bottles, dummies, schedules, timed swaps — each one reduces the signal. Sometimes it's the right tool for a real problem. **Always ask what it costs the supply.**

And **one clear voice beats ten opinions**. Get **one** good lactation professional, and let them win. One — not a different one every day.

What you actually do

- Take the baby between feeds, so she can sleep.
- Feed *her* — food, water, everything.
- Guard the space: quiet and warm, and no hovering visitors.
- Ask how she wants to feed — then **listen without fixing**. It's her body. Your job is the support.

From **Men, Love & Birth** — *the new edition*. There's a whole chapter on feeding.